# WORLD WAR II: THE WEST



**Coming up for air**
German U-boats were used mainly for economic warfare against Allied merchant shipping. With U-boat war patrols lasting between three weeks and six months, any opportunities to get outside for fresh air were welcomed.

**THE OUTBREAK OF** World War II in 1939 came too early for the German navy, which was looking forward to completing a large-scale expansion program by the mid-1940s. Yet Britain's Royal Navy found itself fighting a defensive war on increasingly difficult terms. Germany's military successes in 1940 gave it control of the Norwegian side of the North Sea, France's Atlantic ports, and the southern Channel coast, and deprived the Royal Navy of the support of the French fleet. With Italy also entering the war, British naval forces were desperately stretched. German U-boats came close to severing Britain's lifeline across the Atlantic through the savaging of merchant convoys. Yet while in World War I the Royal Navy had performed disappointingly, despite its superiority, in World War II it showed endurance and aggression under the most demanding circumstances.

## WEAKNESSES AT SEA

The Royal Navy entered the war with some serious drawbacks. Failing to learn from the experience of World War I, the British had inadequate numbers of smaller ships for convoy escort duties to combat U-boats. Too much faith had been put in sonar underwater detection equipment and depth charges as a miracle cure for submarine attack. Corvettes and then frigates were rushed into service to fill this gap, while Canada made an invaluable contribution to convoy defense, followed by the United States from 1941. British inter-war neglect of carrier aircraft—a result of putting them under RAF rather than navy control up to 1937—resulted in the Fleet Air Arm entering the war with some excellent carriers but obsolescent aircraft. On the other side, Germany was slow to put sufficient resources into U-boats, and the Italian navy suffered from technical deficiencies including absence of radar and inadequate intelligence as well as poor command at the highest levels.

## COURAGE AND AGGRESSION

Germany's surface fleet was never powerful enough to challenge the Royal Navy in the way its World War I predecessor had at Jutland. After heavy losses of destroyers in the 1940 Norwegian campaign the German navy was in no position to engage in fleet actions or cover a seaborne invasion of Britain. Its fast modern warships, used as surface raiders, were a serious threat to vital shipping lanes early in the war but they

**British binnacle compass**
Nicknamed "Faithful Freddie," this submarine compass has a binnacle cover and two iron correcting spheres to protect it from magnetic distortion caused by the submarine's iron hull.



